IN HIS HONEYMOON CAGE ON THE FRENCH RIVIERA, THE CIA chief John McCone was growing ever more furious with the lack of new intelligence on the Soviet buildup in Cuba. He was extremely unhappy with his deputy, General Carter, and considered firing him. McCone believed that Carter had mishandled the Cuban situation during his absence: he had not taken the initiative to share his cables with the White House—McCone had never instructed him to do so; he had not stood up to Rusk, whose opposition to U-2 overflights had led to their suspension; and, last but not least, he had approved the Special National Intelligence Estimate of September 19, which suggested that the Soviets would not deploy their missiles in Cuba.[22]

McCone returned to DC on September 26 to the news that a CIA source had spotted a Soviet R-12 ballistic missile (SS-4 Sandal in the American classification) being transported on Cuban roads on September 12. Now he had more reason for concern than ever before. His subordinates were picking up information from Cuban refugees about the extraordinary measures of precaution and secrecy taken by the Cuban police and military to conceal the arrival and deployment of the Soviet military units. The CIA officers were duly putting that information on their maps, but without the U-2 overflights along the entire length of the island there was no way to check the information and assess the scope and the nature of the Soviet buildup.

On October 9, McCone went to see John Kennedy. In attendance were Robert Kennedy, McGeorge Bundy, and other presidential advisers. Together with Deputy Secretary of Defense Roswell Gilpatric, McCone submitted a recommendation to resume the program of overflights of Cuba. Peripheral overflights of Cuba could neither confirm nor disprove the information coming from CIA sources on the ground. McCone needed the resumption of flights over the island itself and was particularly interested in the situation in western Cuba, where the first SAMs had been spotted and which peripheral flights could not reach with their cameras. The U-2 planes were to check the accuracy of reports on the sighting of R-12 MRBMs and assess the readiness of the SAM sites that previous overflights had shown to be under construction in late August and early September.[23]

It had been more than a month since the last U-2 overflight of Cuba on September 5, and the pressure on Kennedy to authorize a new U-2 mission